1st half 12th century

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ASHER IN THE HAREM

by Solomon Ibn Saqbel

"Asher in the Harem" is the first known Hebrew fiction from medieval Spain. According to current opinion, it dates from the first half of the twelfth century. The author, Solomon Ibn Saqbel, is otherwise virtually unknown, only one other story being attributable to him. Of that story so little has been preserved that hardly anything can be said about its contents.

Our story is to be read against the background of ideas of courtly love that were current in medieval Europe. Christians and Muslims studied the phenomenon of love; they developed it into a ritual, celebrated it in poetry, and codified it in handbooks, the most notable of which are Ali Ibn Hazm's *The Ring of the Dove* for Arabic[1] and Andreas Capellanus' *Art of Courtly Love* for Latin.[2] Paramount in both cultures is the idealization of courtly love and the deprecation of vulgarity and frivolousness. The protagonist of our story sees himself as a lover but displays such lack of refinement and so little appreciation for the courtly ideal that he falls prey to a prank hatched by his friend, who is identified only as "the Adulamite."

To understand the story it is necessary to know that Hebrew love poetry of the Golden Age follows the Arabic convention of referring to the beloved as a gazelle or fawn.[3] Thus, when the protagonist, Asher, begins his story by telling us that he spent his youth in the mountains with the

gazelles, he means that he spent his time chasing girls outside the cultivated, conventional world depicted in courtly poetry. He reveals his fecklessness by informing us that he exhausted his resources in this manner, and his casual treatment of human relations by telling us that only this circumstance induced him to return to his family. He flouts the rules of love again when he responds with egoistic pride to the love message inscribed on the apple thrown to him by a lady secluded behind a lattice. By his refusal to respond in a courtly, manly manner to the flirtation he shows himself to be unworthy of dignified love. Accordingly, he is subjected to a series of manipulations designed to bewilder and humiliate him in the very field where he claims expertise, the field of love. The story ends with Asher's marriage to the Adulamite's daughter. Marriage is, of course, the antithesis of courtly love, which thrives on the tension of unfulfilled longing or of illicit relationships. Having begun his career as a lover in the wild, Asher ends up completely domesticated.[4]

The story's form is that of the *maqama*, a genre of Arabic prose writing that emerged in tenth-century Iraq and became very popular in eleventh-century Spain. A *maqama* is a short piece, usually a narrative, written in the distinctive style of formal prose that was fashionable in both Hebrew and Arabic. This style consists of groups of rhymed phrases, in pairs for the most part, roughly even in length, but not metrical as in poetry. The rhymed prose is ornate, abounding in rhetorical figures and rare words. It is occasionally interrupted by short and usually quite banal poems, which sometimes further the action but usually only comment on it. Rhymed prose was an ancient tradition of Arabic writing—it is the prevailing style of the Quran—that was borrowed, together with the various forms of Arabic poetry, by Hebrew writers. It is a style well suited for the elaborate rhetoric favored by Arabic court writers, and even when it came to be used for stories, the narrative element was often subordinate to the rhetoric. Undoubtedly, the thematic inspiration for many such works, which often abounded in gnomic aphorisms and scientific information alongside the narrative, was the international literature of fables, stories, and maxims that originated in India and became popular in both western Europe and the Arabic-speaking world in the twelfth and thirteenth centuries.

Jewish writers in Spain experimented with various combinations of

these thematic and stylistic elements, producing a typically Arabic *maqama* collection in Hebrew (al-Harizi's *Tahkemoni*), a rhymed-prose translation of the Panchatantra (Jacob ben Eleazar's *Kalila wa-dimna*), philosophical allegories (also by Jacob ben Eleazar), a primitive novel (Ibn Zabara's *Sefer Shaashuim*), a series of stories on the wiles of women (especially *Minhat Yehudah* by Ibn Shabbetai, which appears in this anthology under the title "The Misogynist"), and moralistic works (including Ibn Sahula's *Meshal ha-Kadmoni*, a selection of which is found in the present collection, under the title "The Sorcerer").

Other than the language, the Hebrew *maqama* literature has nothing particularly Jewish about it. But to the medieval Jew, the bare fact that this international lore was available in Hebrew was culturally significant, even religiously meaningful. Book after book opens with an author's introduction explaining that his purpose in writing is to demonstrate that the Hebrew language is capable of anything the languages of the nations are capable of. Indeed, in the case of medieval Hebrew, the language does actually tinge the story with religious associations. The Hebrew of the Middle Ages was not a spoken language but a learned language acquired through rote learning of the sources. For reasons that need not concern us, the Bible was considered the linguistic resource for poetry and belles lettres, to the exclusion of the wealth of postbiblical rabbinic literature and poetry. As a result, writers naturally tended to express themselves by citing ready-made phrases from the Bible, and they could rely on the reader to recall effortlessly the biblical context from which the phrase was taken. When rhymed prose became fashionable, writers developed facility at making rhymed clauses by pairing a sentence of their own composition with a snatch of biblical quotation. While the result could be extremely witty, it could also be artificial and, if pursued for too long a stretch, fatiguing for the reader.

Maqamat ordinarily appeared in collections. Each *maqama* in a collection is narrated by someone who tells of a man he met in a certain town (a different town in each *maqama*); at the end of the individual *maqama*, the man is revealed to be the same one who had appeared in all the other *maqamat* of the collection. The individual *maqama* tells of a speech delivered by this character or an escapade in which he is the central figure. The purpose of the speech or the escapade is often to dupe people

into giving the protagonist money. That "Asher in the Harem" was originally part of such a collection was proved by the discovery of a tiny fragment of another story beginning "Said Asher ben Yehuda." In keeping with the conventions of the genre, it seems likely that the manipulator, the Adulamite, appeared in the other *maqamat*. In our story Asher is not merely an observer but is himself the dupe; but that is not without parallel in the Arabic *maqama* collections.

What is without parallel in the *maqama* genre (at least as far as can be said on the basis of the evidence currently available) is our story's portrayal of the relationship between character and love. Whereas in the traditional *maqama* the interest lies in the action or the rhetoric or both, our *maqama* employs action and the rhetoric in the service of the idea that love is something that one must deserve. Because this serious principle underlies and motivates the story, Asher is more than a merely comic character; buffoon though he is, we know him as a person far more deeply than we can ordinarily know either the observer or the protagonist of the classic *maqama*. Thus, our story has a Western feel almost completely lacking in the *maqamat* of Harizi, which, though later, are closer to the Arabic roots of the genre. This quality of "Asher in the Harem" might reflect the emergence of the vernacular love story in Romance languages, though nothing definite can be said on this score at the present stage of research.[5]

Introduction and translation by
RAYMOND P. SCHEINDLIN

Prepare to meet your God, O man!
  The pure of heart He will repay.
Good deeds perform while yet you live;
  Tomorrow get twice what you've laid away.
Enjoy this world and the world to come—
  "Both of my girls you will marry this day."[6]

Said Asher ben Judah: One day I was sitting at the gate with a group of my brethren and kin, and each person was taking his turn telling whatever came to his mind. I said, "Today I confess my sins!"[7] When I was a youth I used to prance like a fawn upon the hills, and in the woods would I dwell. Sabbath and festival I spent apart from men, wearing my color-striped coat, prey for the sweet gazelles.[8] Seasons came and went, and years passed. When at last my clothing wore out, I began to long for home. I arrived in town at night, but my people and the members of my household were not yet in bed. I came and knocked on the door. They had long despaired of me, so when I cried, "I'm, home!" they nearly fainted. Only after they had listened carefully and recognized my voice did they believe it was really I. Then they opened the door for me and kissed me on the face and eyes, exclaiming, "We live again, now that you are back from the dead." They washed my hands and feet, took off my soiled rags, and clothed me lovingly in rich finery. Three days and three nights I stayed with them, eating and drinking.

On the fourth day, sodden with drink and without a care in the world, we went out to stroll along the quiet waters and to sniff some fresh air. By the canals were lovely gazelles and cooing doves.[9] While I was gazing at them and listening to their song, a star peered through a lattice, twinkling from within: an eye winked, a hand beckoned. I kept it to myself while with my companions and stayed with them until they had traversed the passage and reached the wilderness.[10] Then, quick as a buck, I slipped

away and went back to the spot. Just as I passed it, I heard a voice, "Come hither that I may speak with thee and pour my spirit over thee."

I approached. As I stood facing the voice, an apple perfumed with myrrh fell at my feet, and this verse was written on one side:[11]

O you who run to hunt the fair gazelles
  On fragrant hills or on the forest floor,
Have done, for they are kept in harem rooms;
  They pass their lives behind the palace door.[12]

And on the other side was written:

So drunk with wine that you can hardly stand,
  Like willow trees before the storm you shake—
My heart is drunk like yours, and tottering;
  But love is the drink that causes it to ache.

When I read the lines and grasped their meaning,[13] I was so impressed with myself that I blinked at the radiance of my own sun, and I said, "Dashing Asher, that's my name, for girls think me smashing, and the better class of women love me.[14] Has some girl noticed my fine features and fallen in love? By my life, let me tease her. I will stay away, leave her to love, abandon her to agony, and watch to see what happens." So I turned away and paid her no court.

As I wandered along from that lane into another, I took out the apple that had been thrown to me, to read it again and revel in its beauty. Its verses clung to my heart and crumbled it to bits. I now regretted my haste in going away, and I said, "Why did I refuse to reply? I have done wrong not to answer her song." So I passed that day and night drinking no water and eating no bread. I did not even seek out my bed. As soon as dawn rose, I went straight to the place where I had heard the voice the day before. I now lifted my own voice and cried in the direction of the upper chamber:

Hail to the lady whose sorrows are great!
  Hail to the girl from the man she adores.
Hail to the palace's fair gazelle,
  To her who lives by the statutes of love.

Poems of mine is she longing to wear?
  Strings of pearl-verses I'll clasp to her throat.[15]
Is it my friendship she's longing to drink?
  She can have milk of affection from me.
If seeing my beauty would give her heart ease,
  Gladly I'd lie with my head on her knees.

Having made an end to my verses I said no more but stood waiting to learn what would happen. No voice and no word, no answer to be heard! In consternation, frustration, and pain, I rebuked my heart over and over again: "Why do you give the eye to every girl you spy?[16] Why put on a display only to fade away? Why did you not stand your ground when you were spellbound? If you played the king before, how are you now a slave at her door? Act now, and win her somehow. Or go and mope, and give up all hope." Annoyed at my rebuke, my heart replied to this speech:[17]

My soul—your slave—is not herself:
  Into a trap she fell.
What good is it to blame me? I'm
  In love with a gazelle.
My eye it was enslaved my soul—
  How could I rebel?[18]

I spoke to my heart gently and tried to comfort it, but it refused to be comforted in its desolation.

All that day I walked along the rivers and lakes, my eyes pouring streams; and all that night I sang dirges and laments. "I was a brother to the jackal, a friend to the ostrich."[19] When the sun shone and the earth brightened I returned to the lane where I had stood before. There I pleaded and sighed, and groaned and cried,

Bear greetings to the highborn girl,[20]
  The girl whose face like moonlight shines!
And tell her that the man she summoned
  Yesterday has heard her call.
The love that plows her heart with pain
  Has now appeared in his heart too.
He overlooked it yesterday,
  Dazzled by her beauty's ray.

Firm at my post I stood waiting all day, to see whether lightning would flash over me and what it might speak to me. But when I saw the day was closing and no word had come, I lost control and cried, "Why should I hope, when my hope is belied? I look for light, but my darkness deepens. My soul is like a captured buck in the doe's snare. She keeps her bow drawn and releases it only to hasten my death by shooting the arrows of separation into my vitals. She kindles fire in my innards and flame in my heart. She steals my sleep. She has taken her oath to give no rest to my eyes or cure for my complaint."[21]

So I passed the night huddled in one of the streets nearby, in anger and despair, in sorrow and in care. Whenever my strength flagged and I felt I could not go on, I would take out the apple, hold it in my hand, bring it to my nose, and sniff its perfume to revive myself by its fragrance. And when the curtains of night were rolled up and the streams of daylight extended earthward, I came by chance to where I had caught her glance, and I stood once more at the place where I had fallen. With tears on my cheeks, I raised my voice in lament:

By love, O lady born for love—
  By your father's noble name—
By the roses blooming on your cheek—
  By the sweet words flowing on your lips—
By an apple grown to torture me—
  By verses engraved in God's own hand[22]—
Ah! If you will not pity me,
  This love for you will cause my death.
My foes will gnash their teeth with joy,
  And men who hate me will be glad.

When I was done, my mind became confused and I fell senseless on my face. I remained mute, numb, and immobile until I was lifted to my feet by gentle women from the upper chamber, who roused me, saying, "Son of man, stand on your feet so that we may speak with you."[23] Then a spirit came into me and set me on my feet,[24] and I said, "Speak, my ladies, for I am in control of myself again and my strength has returned, thanks to your words." They replied, "We are your servants. We have been sent to you with a message. Hail from the gazelle who dwells in the upper chamber. She has heard your weeping and seen your tears. Her own deep secret will now appear, through the letter we bring you here."

Then I saw that they were bearing a lovely letter, small as a person's palm, dear as diamonds, and perfumed with myrrh. It read:

O you who knock upon the door,
  Never locked to you before—
'Twas you who erred and went away,
  You who caused your own dismay.
Should I open and forgive?
  Or keep it shut and pine away?

When I had read these lines and realized they were meant to rebuke me, my heart burst into flame, my feelings stirred, and my insides simmered with remorse. My hand reached for my cloak, to rend it, but the hem was too tough, for my strength was gone. The maids said to me, "What is all this? Why should you go to such an extreme? Come to yourself! Leave your clothing alone! Be alert, not inert! More bold and more controlled! Follow our footsteps and come along, for we have come to be your guides." I trusted them and followed, not minding the words of Ecclesiastes, "He who goes after her impulsively is like an ox going to slaughter."[25] But the minute I crossed the door I was in fire and water. My hands shook; my steps were unsure. Frantic, I rowed to get back to the shore. I could not.[26] Burning pangs gripped my chest in bands. Then I heard a voice calling, "Strengthen the flagging hands."[27] Hearing this, I took heart. The burning subsided. I answered, "Remember the word to your servant with which you gave me hope. This is my consolation in my misery; your words have revived me."[28]

But those maids were leading me by the ropes of my own folly.[29] They set me on my feet and led me into their courts, then to their chambers, then to the upper room, and finally hurled me into a fowler's trap. Making my way along the gallery to the room where I was to huddle in my lady's shadow, I heard a woman singing clearly, as she strummed on the lute, "Let my love enter his garden and eat his luscious fruits."[30] To this another answered, accompanying herself on the drum, "I have decked my bed with coverings of tapestry, with carved works, with linen of Egypt."[31] When I entered the room and they saw me, they hurried over and threw themselves to the floor at my feet, saying, "Come in, and God's blessing on you!" I sat down on white, blue, and purple spreads of the finest

workmanship, while the girls kept on smiling and kissing the ground before me, as each in turn was saying, "Here comes the lady." But then I saw their expressions turn to horror, their faces black as the mouth of a furnace. "What's wrong?" I asked. "Why has your expression changed? Do you know of some disaster?" They replied, "Here comes the master!"

I looked up and saw. Heading toward me was a man dressed in full armor, drunk with rage, not wine. On his head he wore a white turban. He was burning with jealous fury, his face flaming like a Philistine.[32] He wore a veil and brandished a drawn sword. I got up and threw myself on the floor, crying, "I have sinned, I have strayed from the truth path.[33] Peace, Peace!" I greeted him. But he said: "Have done with your 'Peace'! Who brought you here? Is this how privacy is made public and the secrets of harem rooms exposed? Tell me, who ever endowed you with arrogance and blinded you with lust?" I was shocked dumb; I had no strength to put words together, not even to speak. He went on: "Have you betrayed and now are dismayed? Have you lied and now are tongue-tied? Have you transgressed and are now distressed?[34] Speak! Whom did you trust when you flamed with lust? On whom did you rely when you made your bold try? What foolish dare got you into this snare? You have breached the etiquette of nobles and rent the veil of royalty.[35] By my life, you are going to die. Today your time is up, and I am going to watch your fall." He grabbed me and shook me by the gown and said, "Take off your clothes and enjoy the fruits of your labors." My heart melted like wax, my will turned to water; death-terrors engulfed me and I knew the pangs of hell. But when he saw me trembling in dread that I was soon to be dead, tears welled in his eyes, and unveiling, he cried, "Son of man, open your eyes and beyold the visage before thee." I looked up and saw there a shining light and a cheek radiant as the sky in its splendor. My tongue awoke, and I asked, "What is this, my lord?" He replied, "My master! I am but a girl of the chamber, a gazelle of the court. I have never dwelt in the forests, nor have I known the cloven mountains. I am a girl of the palace, in opulence bred."

check this for this — like [illegible]

use meter in poetry not etc.

A fawn am I, who with her lashes hunts
  The lusty youths, and traps them in her snare.
Gracious am I to whom I will; I give
  To every man who merits it his share.

Seeing that her effulgence overpowered me, she covered it with her hair. I said, "Blessed art thou by God, my child. This second kindness of yours is even greater than the first.[36] It must have been you who hailed me from the chamber, then assailed me; who seduced me with the apple, then traduced me."[37] She replied, "No, my lord. She is the lady of ladies, who puts the stars to shame. Her lip is lovely, her look is lust. I would compare her (were comparisons not sacrilege) to the light of the sun, but seven times brighter. I am but a slave of her slaves, a mere menial, for your amusement sent, on your pleasure bent. For she said, 'Let me appease him with the gift that goes before me, and afterward I will come into his presence; perhaps he will receive me kindly.'[38] She shall be brought into the king in raiment of needlework; the girls her companions that follow shall be brought to you."[39] Yet hardly had she finished her speech when I heard the bustling of a throng and the sound of a gong, and I scented frankincense and cinnamon. Looking up, I beheld a parade of lovely, choice maidens, one of whom was taller by head and shoulder than the others and so brilliant she made their shadows flee at her advance. Ornaments of majesty she wore; her robe was hung with bells. The veil of nobility covered her brow; she swayed as she walked, like a myrtle bough. Stately she made her way, towering over her companions, who accompanied her progress with song, to drums and fifes:

In Heb. this is Hagiwal prose, not poetry

Tell us why you seem to sway—
  Does frailty make you walk that way
Or is it drinking old Tokay?[40]

But I could not see her eyes, because of her veil.

Having ensconced her, they left her presence, and I remained alone with the lady at my side. Then I said to myself, Now's the time to butter up your tongue and go to the work you know so well. Turning to face her, I cried, "You have set me on fire, my sister, my bride; you have set me afire with a single one of your eyes, with a single link of your necklace. Reveal your light, my dear; spread over me your hair; remove from your face the veil; let your charms appear."[41] But when I took off the headdress and the veil I beheld a long beard, a face like death and a mouth open wide as a steaming cauldron, and it said: "How dared you look at the

cheeks and the crimson lips!" In terror I collapsed full length upon the floor, my face burning and my pleasure gone. But he laughed heartily enough to be heard far and wide as he took hold and comforted me, saying, "Don't take fright! It's all right! I'm your friend, the Adulamite. Have a drink. Taste a bite. Haven't you always known that I'm a trickster?" I opened my eyes and saw it was my friend, dear to me as my own flesh. I said, "It was on account of Rachel that I served you! Why have you deceived me and made a fool out of me?"[42] But he went on consoling me. He plied me with bread and fed me delicious food, and I stayed with him for a few days. Then he gave me his daughter to be my bride, and much of his family riches beside.

Enjoy my charming story, gentle friends,
But don't be taken in by what you've heard.
A tale of lover's folly this, no more,
A pack of lies—I made up every word!

NOTES

1. Translation by A. J. Arberry (London, 1953).
2. Translation by John Jay Parry (New York, 1941).
3. See Raymond P. Scheindlin, *Wine, Women, and Death: Medieval Hebrew Poems on the Good Life* (Philadelphia: Jewish Publication Society, 1986), index, s.v. "gazelle."
4. See Raymond P. Scheindlin, "Fawns of the Palace and Fawns of the Field," *Prooftexts* 8 (1986), 189–203, for a full discussion of the cultural presuppositions of the story.
5. The Hebrew text was published by Hayyim Schirmann in *Yediot ha-Makhon le-Heker ha-Shirah ha-Ivrit* 2(1936), 62–152; 193; 6(1945), 325, with a comprehensive introduction, and again, in *Ha-Shirah ha-Ivrit bi-Sefarad u-ve-Provans* (Jerusalem, 1954), 1, 554–65. See also Ezra Fleischer, *Inyene shira ufiyut* in *Mehqere sifrut mugashim leshim'on halkin*, ed. by Ezra Fleischer (Jerusalem, 1975), 202–4. There is a prose translation by David S. Segal in an article entitled, "*Mahberet neum 'asher ben yehuda'* of Solomon Ibn Saqbel: A study of Scriptural Citation Clusters," *Journal of the American Oriental Society*, 102 (1982), 17–26.
6. A witty application of 1 Samuel 18:21, where similar words are addressed by King Saul to the young David with reference to Saul's own daughters. The frivolous use of the quotation underlines the tongue-in-cheek character of the poem, with its venal message couched in homiletical style.
7. Genesis 41:9.

8. The word translated "festival" means literally "new moon," the first day of the lunar month, which was celebrated as a holy day in biblical times. Joseph's coat of many colors is the customary clothing of the dandy in medieval Hebrew poetry. I use "gazelle" or "fawn" interchangeably to represent all the animals that conventionally stand for the beloved in this poetry.
9. The gazelles and doves here may be stone foundations, and their singing, the plash of the water in a garden pool; or they may represent groups of girls walking along a river or even doing laundry on its banks.
10. Either the passage leads out of a palace complex, like the Alhambra, or out of an enclosed quarter within a city. The "wilderness" would mean the space outside the palace or the city streets outside the quarter. A third possibility is that the passage leads through the city gate or over a bridge to the open country beyond.
11. Apples sent as a gift sometimes figure as "messengers" of love; see Ewald Wagner, *Abu Nuwas: Eine Studie zur arabischen Literatur der frühen Abbasidenzeit* (Wiesbaden: Franz Steiner Verlag, 1965), 326–27. The verses in our narrative were presumably inscribed in the peel. For a similar case, see the love story by Jacob ben Eleazar published by H. Schirmann in *Yediot ha-Makhon le-Heker ha-Shirah ha-Ivrit* 5 (1939): 150.
12. Literally in the "room of rooms," i.e., a room within rooms. The Hebrew reflects the Arabic *mukhdara*, meaning "a woman kept secluded."
13. Almost this very expression occurs in the *1001 Nights*, trans. E. W. Lane (New York: Williams and Norgate, 1927), 4. According to Lane (p. 975 n.15), it is necessary to mention that the reader understood the letter because of the elaborate style of such compositions.
14. A desperate attempt to render the Hebrew pun, borrowed by the author from Genesis 30:13. There Leah names her son Asher, saying that women would declare her blessed *(ishsheruni)*.
15. The comparison of verses of poetry to strings of pearls is a commonplace of Arabic and medieval Hebrew rhetoric. The very word used for "verses" in Hebrew means "a string of pearls." The comparison is apt, not simply because of the esteem in which poetry was held, but because of the way in which verses of the *qasida* seem to be strung together with little grammatical relationship between them. See Moses Ibn Ezra, *Kitāb al-muhādara wa'l-mudhākara*, ed. and trans. into Hebrew by A. S. Halkin (Jerusalem: *M'kize Nirdamim*, 1975), 24–26; Raymond P. Scheindlin, *Form and Structure in the Poetry of al-Mu'tamid Ibn Abbad* (Leiden: E. J. Brill, 1974), 1–16. I have translated the verb *a 'aniqeha* as if it were derived from Hebrew *'anaq* (necklace) or Arabic *'unuq* (neck), rather than as the verb meaning "to give."
16. Asher's rebuke to himself recalls the words of Andreas Capellanus, *The Art of Courtly Love*, trans. John Jay Parry (New York and London: W. W. Norton & Co., 1969), 33.
17. The momentary severance of the speaker from his own heart, with which, thanks to personification, he is able to carry on a dialogue, is sufficiently rare in medieval Hebrew prose to deserve notice.

18. The last verse, literally translated, reads, "What can I do? My eye wronged my soul."

19. Job 30:29. The jackal and the ostrich are proverbial mourners in biblical poetry. This verse and several others referring to the same animals are often cited in poems on the destruction of Jerusalem and other lugubrious liturgical poems for fast days. The quotation is apt here, since the reference to these creatures of the wilderness underscores the speaker's "outsideness" with respect to the woman; and the polarity outside/inside shapes the whole story.

20. Literally "delicate lady." I have allowed myself the liberty for the sake of the meter. I believe it is justified by its usage in Isaiah 47:8 as part of an extended metaphor of Babylon as a princess.

21. The rhyme, which throughout the story is organized in phrases of roughly regular length, becomes rhythmically uneven in this tirade, an effect that is probably intended to suggest breakdown, but which I could not imitate in the translation without rhyming the entire story.

22. This expression, used of Moses' tablets in Exodus 31:18, led the rabbis to speculate on the miraculous character of the engraving on the tablets. See Louis Ginzberg, *Legends of the Jews* (Philadelphia: Jewish Publication Society, 1911), 3:119.

23. Ezekiel 2:1. The language of the harem ladies continues to parody prophetic revelations.

24. Ezekiel 3:24.

25. The quotation is actually from Proverbs 7:22, which describes a foolish youth following a prostitute. My translation "impulsively" is not the usual interpretation, but I think it is borne out by the imagery in the following verse.

26. A parody of Jonah 1:13.

27. Isaiah 35:3, a prophecy of consolation.

28. Psalm 119:49–50. Reciting hopeful verses from the psalms was a traditional way of alleviating anxiety.

29. "Ropes" results from a tiny alteration to the Hebrew text, which, as it stands, reads "vanity."

30. Song of Songs 4:16, the song of the shepherdess to her rustic swain.

31. Proverbs 7:16, the seductive address of the prostitute, mentioned in note 25 above, to the foolish youth.

32. "Philistines" in Andalusian Hebrew literature usually means Berbers, following the general practice of medieval Hebrew writers of designating contemporary nations by biblical names. The Berbers were depicted in both Arabic and Hebrew sources as uncultured and bellicose. It was the custom of Berber men of the period to wear veils.

33. Job 33:27.

34. A parody of the confrontation between Elijah and Ahab, 2 Kings 21:19.

35. The Hebrew word *seter* means "secrecy" or "privacy"; but the Arabic cognate means "veil," and sometimes, as here, it stands for the concept of the harem as a whole.

36. Ruth 3:10.

37. Song of Songs 8:25, with the meaning slightly altered.

38. Genesis 32:21.

39. Psalm 45:15, describing a royal wedding.

40. The lady is singing a poem by the author's more famous contemporary, Judah Halevi, found in Halevi's *Diwan*, ed. Heinrich Brody (Berlin: *M'kize Nirdamim*, 1909), 2:49. The verse quoted here refers to the gait typically ascribed to the beloved in stylized love poetry. "Tokay" of course is a Hungarian wine, certainly not found in medieval Andalusia. The Hebrew has simply "wine."

41. The first sentence of this speech is a quotation from Song of Songs 4:9.

42. In Genesis 29:25 almost the same words are spoken by Jacob upon discovering that Leah has been substituted for Rachel on his wedding night.